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This industrial AI startup
is winning over
customers by saying it
won't get acquired



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- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

problems in supply chain, manufacturing, and software infrastructure, which is exactly what Schematic is focused on as an early-stage fund.

Julian Counihan, the Schematic partner who made the investment, told TechCrunch that there are a few ways startups can try to allay these kinds of concerns for customers. There are practical solutions — say, putting code in escrow, or offering a free, perpetual license to the software if an

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- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
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It's this commitment that seems to be helping CVector find early success.

Zhang and Ruggles each bring unique skills that play well with the type of work CVector provides its customers. One of Zhang's earliest jobs was working as a software engineer for oil giant Shell, where he said he was often in the field "building

iPad apps for people who've never used an iPad before."

Ruggles, who has a PhD in experimental particle physics, spent time working at the Large Hadron Collider "working with nanosecond data, trying to ensure very high uptime, being held accountable for downtime and rapidly troubleshooting."

"Those are places where you get to build up that

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might mean the surrounding roads and parking lots get salted. If that salt gets carried into a factory on workers' boots, it can have a tangible impact on the high-precision equipment that operators might not have previously noticed or been able to explain.

"Bringing those kinds of signals into your operations and your planning is incredibly



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valuable,” Ruggles said. “All of this is to help run these facilities more successfully, more profitably.”

CVector has already deployed its industrial AI agents in sectors like chemicals, automotive, and energy, and has its eyes set on what Zhang refers to as “large-scale critical infrastructure.”

With energy providers specifically, Zhang said a common problem is that their grid dispatch



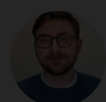
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While the process was doing a bit more, it's been submitted, get it through the peer review process and get it published in a journal and hope that somebody looks at it, that I'm working with a client on something that's in the ground and that we could be helping them keep it up and running,” he said. “You can make changes, build up features, and build new stuff for your customers — rapidly.”



Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation | X

Sean O'Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology o...

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Alex Wilhelm — 3:00 AM PST · December 8, 2020

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Zhang and Parik initially worked on a product that would have allowed other companies to embed consumer lending into their own service. But, in Zhang's telling, the pair ran into the pandemic, the early period of which was anathema to interest in extending more credit to regular folks. (Notably [Upstart](#), a fintech focused on facilitating consumer lending, is [in the process of going public](#); how rapidly 2020 has spun industries around.)

However, a design partner wanted to offer PPP loans to SMBs on its platform, so the pair wound up looking into what was required for the project on the data side of the ask; Finch was born out of those learnings.

Finch connects customers to payroll and HR data via an API, offering both a free version of its product to entice developers, and a paid version of the product that is priced either as a pay-as-you-go service.



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Something about the startup, it's young. The founding group put up a landing page for the company in April, and wrote the first code for the project in July. That's rapid scaling from zero to in-market traction. Today Finch is growing 50% month-over-month in terms of both revenue and "employers connected," giving it the sort of growth that investors flock to.

What might one be able to build with Finch's API? Past a few basic ideas, my brain was bereft, so I

asked Zhang to dole out the future to me. In the co-founder's estimation, there are three core buckets where Finch can have a role: financial software, inside the lending and insurances spaces, and supporting the burgeoning HR and benefits software market.

In each area, having access to what Zhang called a "source of truth," namely HR and payroll data about employees and their employment, would allow



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[\\$3 million](#) in funding after initially targeting a raise in the \$1 million range.

The startup has six staff today, with Zhang expecting the the company to scale to 15 or 20 by the end of next year.

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Alex Wilhelm

Senior Reporter | X 🍷 in

Alex Wilhelm was a senior reporter for TechCrunch covering the markets, venture capital and startups. He w...

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Kirsten Korosec — 5:27 PM PDT · April 21, 2025

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RAMSEY CARDY/SPORTSFILE FOR COLLISION /
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Aidan Gomez, the co-founder and CEO of generative AI startup Cohere, has joined the board of EV maker Rivian, [according to a regulatory filing](#). The appointment is the latest sign that Rivian sees promises in applying AI to its own venture while positioning itself as a software leader — and even provider — within the automotive industry.

Rivian increased the size of the board and elected Gomez, whose term will expire in 2026, according to the filing.

Gomez and AI entrepreneur and Cohere founder are on training. The generative AI company

Prior to joining Rivian, Gomez worked at Google. Gomez joined a 2017 tech foundation. AI models

Gomez joined Rivian and a [joint venture](#) software. Its electric Volkswagen

and is expected to license existing intellectual property rights to the joint venture.

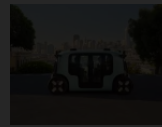
It's possible the joint venture will sell its tech to other companies in the future.

Rivian has also been working on an AI assistant for its EVs since 2023, Rivian's chief software officer, Wassym Bensaid, told TechCrunch during an

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Kirsten Korosec - 13 hours ago



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interview in March. The AI work, which is specifically on the orchestration layer or framework for an AI assistant, sits outside the joint venture with VW, Bensaid mentioned at the time.

TE

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

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Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

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